

SYMPTOMS AND FIXES FOR ADD

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Identify symptoms of ADD that have been experienced over the past 6 months.
2. Become familiar with the preliminary elements of some treatment techniques.
3. Understand that treatment involves more than just taking medication.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- None

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Adult ADD is a syndrome that is revealed in a myriad of different symptoms. Review the client's checklist of symptoms that he/she has experienced and allow them to discuss any of them in more detail. It is also important to focus the client's attention on the intervention strategies that are a part of successful treatment. Many clients have the notion that medication alone is the complete answer to their struggles. They may have questions that need to be answered about the coping skills that are briefly described in this homework assignment. Provide the client with as much detail as necessary for their understanding of these techniques. Reinforce those strategies that you believe will be beneficial to them and that will be the focus for future treatment sessions.

SYMPTOMS AND FIXES FOR ADD

Attention Deficit Disorder (ADD) is characterized by a variety of symptoms or signs. Although you may have become aware of having ADD as an adult, the symptoms of distractibility, short attention span, impulsivity, and restlessness most likely began in childhood. This assignment encourages you to review your life and indicate what symptoms are a part of your experience. We then take a brief look at a list of coping skills that commonly help ADD clients.

Symptom Checklist

1. Check all the symptoms that you have experienced within the last 6 months.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Loss of concentration | ☐ Disorganized |
| ☐ Easily distracted | ☐ Rarely finish projects |
| ☐ Restless and fidgety | ☐ Easily irritated (short fuse) |
| ☐ Impulsive actions | ☐ Easily frustrated |
| ☐ Rapid mood swings | ☐ Low self-esteem |
| ☐ Tendency for addictive behaviors | ☐ Interrupt or intrude on others |
| ☐ Inconsistent work and effort | ☐ Fail to listen |
| ☐ Poor sense of time | ☐ Make careless mistakes |
| ☐ Easily overwhelmed | ☐ Poor time management |
| ☐ Difficulty switching activities | ☐ Enjoy high-risk behaviors |
| ☐ Feel “driven by a motor” | ☐ Chronic lateness |
| ☐ Talk excessively | ☐ Easily bored |
| ☐ Frequently lose things | ☐ Poor employment history |
| ☐ Blurt out answers | ☐ Feel anxious |
| ☐ Impatient in awaiting turn | ☐ Often depressed |
| ☐ Forgetful in daily duties | ☐ Poor eye contact |

2. List the three most problematic symptoms.

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____

3. Why are these symptoms the most problematic? What are the consequences for you of each of these three symptoms?

- A. _____
- B. _____
- C. _____

4. **Fixes**

Following is a list of coping techniques that are used to assist people who struggle with ADD. Review the list and place a checkmark next to those that you think might be most helpful for you to receive further guidance with as your treatment progresses.

- _____ *Medication:* One of the most common treatments for ADD is the prescription of stimulant medication by a physician. There are various types of these medications and they are prescribed in various dosages to fit individual needs.
- _____ *Problem-Solving Skills:* The client is taught how to approach problems in a systematic way and analyze the pros and cons of various solutions before making a decision for action. This approach is a replacement for the impulsivity that characterizes many ADD clients.
- _____ *Stop, Listen, Think, Act:* This technique is also designed to curb impulsivity. The client is taught to listen carefully to the requirements of a situation and then to think about what action should be taken in response to the situation before engaging in a behavior.
- _____ *Positive Self-Talk:* The client is taught to give himself/herself positive messages to counteract feelings of low self-esteem, inadequacy, depression, and anxiety.
- _____ *Time Out:* This procedure is commonly used to help clients reduce their irritability and impulsivity by training them to remove themselves from stimulus situations for a short time before reacting. This allows for consideration of consequences and engaging actions in a more planful manner.
- _____ *Relaxation:* Many clients with ADD are fidgety and restless, anxious, and on edge. Learning to implement relaxation techniques is a major help in reducing stress and reactivity.
- _____ *Self-Reward:* Self-reward procedures are implemented to assist ADD clients in completing tasks that are often left incomplete. This procedure is also helpful in motivating clients to be focused in their actions.
- _____ *Reminder Aids:* Forgetfulness and lack of organization are common traits of ADD clients. Learning to use checklists, notes written to self, organization calendars, and day planners are useful techniques.
- _____ *Physical Exercise:* To reduce the restless, fidgety energy that is common to ADD clients, physical exercise on a regular basis is often implemented. The exercise reduces stress and

— *Distraction Reduction:* The client learns to arrange the environment such that sounds, sights, people, or objects that could lead to distraction are minimized or removed.

 Talk Time: It is important for many ADD clients to have the opportunity to sit and talk without distractions. This allows for structured time to be set aside where distractions are minimal and thoughts are followed through to completion. Significant others also benefit from this communication opportunity.

- [illegible]